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Professional Statement on the Use of Artificial Intelligence

This statement reflects where I am right now in my thinking about artificial intelligence in my professional work. It is not a final position. I am still working through many of these questions, and I expect this statement to look different in a year or two.

I. CONTEXT

I became Founding Head of the School of Foundational Studies (SoFS) in June 2025, which means I am standing up a new academic unit at a moment when questions about AI in higher education are particularly unsettled. That timing shapes how I think about this. The decisions made now about how the SoFS approaches AI will have some staying power, so I am trying to be deliberate rather than reactive. This statement is part of that effort.

II. HOW I CURRENTLY USE AI

I use AI, primarily Claude (Anthropic's AI assistant), regularly across most areas of my work. On the administrative side, this includes producing documents like budget reports, curriculum memos, faculty communications, and enrollment analyses, some of which involve scripted pipelines that generate formatted Word files from structured data. In communications, I use AI to refine drafts of memos, letters, and newsletter columns; I bring the substance, and AI helps shape them. For curriculum work, I have used it to help organize reports and recommendations for the SoFS Curriculum Council and the University Curriculum Committee.

I also use AI in building course materials and syllabi. The throughline in all of this is that AI handles execution on tasks where I have already done the thinking. The judgment, the context, and the decisions remain mine.

III. THE BENEFITS I SEE

The most practical benefit is capacity. My role is broad, and AI allows me to produce work at a level of quality and volume that would otherwise be difficult to sustain. For colleagues, I think the value is similar: less friction on editing and administrative tasks, more time for the work that actually requires human presence. For students, the potential benefit is access to feedback and explanation outside of office hours, though I think the how and when of that access matters a great deal.

IV. MY CONCERNS

My main concern is that AI makes it easy to skip the productive struggle that builds real competence. In foundational education, especially, the difficulty is not incidental; it is the mechanism (it's the process, not the product, so to speak). Students who reach for AI before they have developed enough judgment to evaluate the output are not being helped; they are being shortchanged. I also worry about institutional policy drifting so far behind actual practice that it becomes meaningless, and about colleagues being left to figure all of this out without much support.

V. THE PRINCIPLES I TRY TO FOLLOW

A few things guide how I use AI in practice.

- I try to be transparent about when and how I use it. I do not think there is anything to hide, and modeling openness seems important given my role.
- I keep consequential judgments human. Decisions that affect people, including faculty, students, and the direction of the school, are mine to make, not to delegate.
- I think about fitness for purpose. Not every task benefits from AI involvement, and some are better done without it.
- I try to hold myself to the same standard I hold my students to.

I lead a school built on the value of foundational learning. I should not quietly let my own tools erode the habits of mind I am asking students to develop.

VI. AI IN MY COURSES

My AI policy varies by course and assignment, but the underlying message to students is consistent: the difficulty is not the obstacle, it is the point. In foundational education, the struggle to work through a problem, construct an argument, or derive a result is where learning actually happens. A student who offloads that struggle to AI may produce a correct answer, but they have skipped the process that builds the competence the answer is supposed to represent. I try to make that distinction explicit with my students rather than simply restricting or permitting AI use by rule. The policy question I keep coming back to is not whether AI is allowed, but whether its use in a given moment serves the student's development or substitutes for it.

VII. WHERE I EXPECT THIS TO GO

In administration, I expect to consolidate what I have built and make it accessible to others rather than continue adding to it. In teaching, the more significant shift will come, in my opinion, as AI-assisted problem-solving becomes part of the subject matter in some of my courses rather than something to accommodate around the edges. At the school level, the work moves from designing a framework to actually using it, which will involve supporting colleagues through questions I am still working through myself. I expect my use of AI to become more deliberate over time, though not necessarily more extensive.

VIII. MY COMMITMENTS

I am committed to using AI transparently and with integrity. I am committed to staying informed as the tools and their implications continue to change. I am committed to helping students develop the judgment they need to use AI effectively, rather than just using it. And I am committed to keeping human judgment at the center of my work, even as I rely on these tools to help me do more of it.

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